

Brushstrokes of Rebellion: An Analysis of Artistic Expression in Chopin's *The Awakening* and Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper"

In the nineteenth century, the diagnosis of "women's diseases" like hysteria and depression resulted in restricting women from engaging in writing, painting, or similar types of intellectual work. These "women's diseases" were a category of diagnoses that were commonly given to women, usually with no basis. According to a research paper from Paula A. Treichler titled "Escaping the Sentence: Diagnosis and Discourse in 'The Yellow Wallpaper,'" these arts are central to the medical repression depicted in "The Yellow Wallpaper" and can be extended to similar works (61). In both *The Awakening* and "The Yellow Wallpaper," artistic expression becomes a form of resistance, transformation, and identity. Kate Chopin and Charlotte Perkins Gilman use music, painting, and writing to show how art acts as an escape for women living under large gender expectations. Through an emotional piano piece, painted self-reflection, and secret journal entries, art becomes a window into forbidden desires and freedom. In both texts, creativity shows the gap between social expectations and inner desires, demonstrates how art allows women to define themselves beyond their given roles, and ultimately reveals the dangers women face when their artistic awakenings clash with societal expectations. Chopin's *The Awakening* and Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" suggest art reveals the creative, locked-away desires of women while threatening the societal expectations that confine them.

Firstly, Chopin uses music in *The Awakening* as a metaphor for Edna Pontellier's unexpressed desires, suggesting that art exposes what society refuses to acknowledge. Edna's response to Mademoiselle Reisz's unfolds like a door opening into a secret world. Unlike the previous pieces, which gave her images of solitude and despair, Mademoiselle Reisz's piece stirs "the very passions themselves were aroused within her soul" (Chopin 29). Her music reveals that artistic experience exposes parts of Edna that she cannot express. While Edna's roles as wife and mother constrain her, the power of art introduces her hidden desires. Music threatens the public identity she performs by revealing the existence of a locked-up identity that is entirely her own. Her emotional reaction to the piano leads her to learn how to swim for the first time, as "a feeling of exultation overtook her" (Chopin 31) when she finally succeeded. This experience, which stemmed from the piano, further ingrains an individualistic mindset in Edna. She experiences that moment as a revelation, showing that art enables her to differentiate between society's wants and her actual desires.

Similarly, Gilman shows that the narrator's journal writing in "The Yellow Wallpaper" becomes a hidden archive of her identity. Because her husband forbids her from openly expressing her thoughts, the journal serves as a private space in which her genuine emotions, creativity, and sense of self can exist without punishment, like a compact therapist. Her husband instills in her mind that "the very worst thing I can do is to think about my condition" (Gilman 2), forcing her to hide her journal before her husband comes in. That secrecy shows how the narrator's creative identity exists outside her societal identity. While she is perceived on the outside as mentally unstable, her writing reveals a unique perspective on how she interprets the world. She describes the wallpaper as having a personality, noticing how the pattern is "committing every artistic sin" (Gilman 3). Her creative language reveals an imprisoned mind.

This inner voice creates a powerful contrast with her outward expressiveness. The gap between her creative inner self and controlled public self becomes so wide that the narrator eventually splits from reality. Through this contrast, Gilman suggests that a creative lens is the only way the narrator can understand herself.

Moreover, Chopin argues that artistic expression gives Edna something no one else can claim or control: a sense of self-ownership. When Edna begins painting, she experiences a sense of pride and independence. Painting becomes a symbol of her life; it belongs to her alone, not to her children, husband, or reputation. Edna's desire to paint is strong, as she forgets societal expectations of her as a result. Painting is such an issue that Mr. Pontellier has to step in and tell Edna, "Don't let the family go to the devil" (Chopin 64). This shift in priorities is significant, as the ability to do motherly chores defines a woman's worth in her world. Painting allows Edna to break those rules by placing her desires above her chores. Art also further becomes connected to freedom; she begins to imagine living alone, selling her work, and shaping her identity through her creations. While society interprets art as a hobby for women, Edna uses it as a pathway towards individualism. Edna directly challenges her domestic identity with this, suggesting that artistic expression redefines her relationship to motherhood, marriage, and herself.

Likewise, Gilman presents creativity as the narrator's attempt to preserve individuality against authority. Although she is ordered not to think, she uses metaphors and symbolism to interpret her experiences through her own terms. The wallpaper's pattern becomes a canvas for interpretation and rebellion. She describes the trapped woman inside the wallpaper as a symbol of her own confinement. The woman in the wallpaper "seemed to shake the pattern, just as if she wanted to get out" (Gilman 9), which could similarly be seen as the narrator's desire to be let out. The narrator's strong imagination transforms this hidden person into a living metaphor.

Through her interpretations, she claims authority over her environment. The wallpaper, meant to decorate a child's nursery, now becomes a symbol of her imprisonment instead of a byproduct of it. Her creativity looks through and reshapes reality, even when she is told she cannot trust her own mind. As the narrator further interprets the pattern, she asserts her identity against the narrative, defining her as insane. Through interpretation and writing, she expresses her true thoughts about her situation in a way that is easily understood.

Additionally, during the late nineteenth century, middle-class culture often treated women's art as a "ladylike accomplishment." It is valuable when it decorates the home or demonstrates refinement, but malicious when it becomes a serious ambition or professional identity. In an article by Robert Shaw, he describes girls' academics in the nineteenth century and presents their art alongside it. Girls' schooling commonly included drawing, painting, needlework, and music as socially acceptable forms of decorative skill intended to polish femininity rather than to prepare careers (Shaw). In music, especially, this expectation encouraged performance in private spaces rather than composition or paid work. Women were encouraged to play and please rather than create on their own terms. Even when women pursued art seriously, institutions and professional culture constrained them through limited training and narrower genres, forcing many to work within traditional subjects or fight for access and recognition. In an article by Anne Stiles, she describes a gendered view of creativity that commonly appeared in medical and marital power called a "rest cure." The era's idea of the "rest cure" could explicitly forbid women from intellectual and artistic work, ordering them to "never touch pen, brush, or pencil as long as you live," which framed creativity itself as dangerous to a woman's health and obedience (Stiles). Together, these pressures show an age that praises women's art as a trinket, but polices it as soon as it becomes self-defining.

In like manner, “The Yellow Wallpaper” directly criticizes the “rest cure” through the narrator’s forced lack of physical and intellectual activity, revealing how the treatment suppresses women’s creativity. The narrator explains that her husband, John, a physician, insists she avoid all mental stimulation, stating that she is “absolutely forbidden to ‘work’ until I am well again” (Gilman 1). This prohibition includes writing, which the narrator views as necessary for relief, stating that “if I were only well enough to write a little it would relieve the press of ideas and rest me” (Gilman 4). John’s authority as both a husband and doctor reflects the actual medical practice of the rest cure, which prescribed isolation, silence, and absolute dependence on others as a cure for similar ailments. He dismisses her imagination as illness, telling her that “nothing was worse for a nervous patient than to give way to such fancies” (Gilman 4). As a result, the narrator is confined to a former nursery, denied artistic or academic outlets, and reduced to obedience. Gilman uses this treatment to show that the rest cure does not heal the narrator but instead worsens her condition by erasing her creative identity. By forcing her into stillness and silence, the rest cure transforms her creativity into rebellion and ultimately drives the narrator towards psychological collapse.

Thus, in both *The Awakening* and “The Yellow Wallpaper,” art becomes an assertion of identity that reveals the deeper realities of women and threatens the expectations that restrict them. Chopin and Gilman use painting, writing, and music to show how creativity exposes desires that conflict with societal expectations. Through Edna’s emotional response to music and her turn to painting, creativity awakens a new understanding of herself beyond motherhood and marriage. Likewise, Gilman’s narrator uses her writing and imaginative interpretation to resist control, transforming something as simple as wallpaper into a metaphor for her confinement. Both authors portray art not as a simple decoration or leisure, but as a force capable of reshaping

identities and revealing truths. In both texts, artistic expression becomes a fault line beneath social order, revealing the instability of roles imposed on women and the fracturing of the structures that confine them. However, this fracturing comes at a significant cost: isolation, misunderstanding, and even one's eventual collapse. Their creative awakenings threaten existing authority by revealing the emotional and mental depth that society insists women lack. These women show that creativity is a powerful form of rebellion that reveals inner realities while dismantling the system designed to lock them away.

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